SOURCE BOOKLET
OPEN AWARDS
ENGLISH FUNCTIONAL SKILLS LEVEL 2

The Level 2 Functional Skills Qualification in English: Reading exam will assess your ability to:

- identify the different situations when the main points are sufficient and when it is important to have specific details
- compare information, ideas and opinions in different texts, including how they are conveyed
- identify implicit and inferred meaning in texts
- understand the relationship between textual features and devices, and how they can be used to shape meaning for different audiences and purposes
- use a range of reference materials and appropriate resources for different purposes, including to find the meanings of words in straightforward and complex sources
- understand organisational features and use them to locate relevant information in a range of straightforward and complex sources
- analyse texts, of different levels of complexity, recognising their use of vocabulary and identifying levels of formality and bias
- follow an argument, identifying different points of view and distinguishing fact from opinion
- identify different styles of writing and writer's voice

Text 1

https://www.theguardian.com/fashion/2021/sep/20/circular-fashion-greenwashing-myth-or-attainable-goal

‘Circular’ fashion: greenwashing myth, or attainable goal?

Hopes for recyclable fashion are far from mass market reality, warns a new documentary at London Fashion Week



Photograph: Paul Painter/Alamy

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Circularity – a concept drawing on principles such as “designing out” waste and ensuring clothing can be remade again and again – is the buzzword at London fashion week.

At Preen by Thornton Bregazzi, the designers Justin Thornton and Thea Bregazzi spliced together clashing rolls of floral fabric “that had been hanging around in the studio, left over from different seasons” and designed one entirely new look.



A dress made of mixed leftover fabrics designed by Justin Thornton and Thea Bregazzi for Preen by Thornton Bregazzi, presented at London fashion week.

The dress, with pink blossom above the waist, multicoloured wildflowers below and two further floral prints on the back – accessorised, for London fashion week, with a space-age black visor edged with a neoprene frill – allowed the duo scope to be creative and offer customers a new look, while reducing their environmental footprint. But a new documentary warns that circularity may not be an effective strategy for sustainability – as it has been billed in some quarters – when applied to mass-produced clothes, which account for the vast majority of the fashion industry.

“The clothes you see at London fashion week have a good chance of having a decent life,” said Veronica Bates Kassatly, an independent analyst of sustainability claims, at a screening of Fashionscapes: A Circular Economy. High-cost clothes were more likely to be worn multiple times “and the prices mean that it makes economic sense for shoppers to repair rather than replace,” said Bates Kassatly. She noted that she was recently quoted £45 by a cobbler to fix a pair of worn-out shoes, a price at which many consumers would choose to buy a new pair instead.

The short film shows bales of discarded fashion items arriving by tanker at Kantamanto market in Ghana. While some of the clothing is mended or upcycled, much of it is of too poor quality to reuse or has been thoughtlessly constructed with embellishments and extra fastenings that render the garments useless. Clothes sent to Kantamanto are often recorded as having been “recycled”, but 40% leave the market again as landfill. “This is circularity as greenwashing,” says Andrew Morgan, the director of Fashionscapes.

Livia Firth, the sustainability activist hosting the film, said that circularity had “become a marketing tool which allows big brands to put a recycling bin in their store while continuing to use supply chains that wreak havoc on the natural world”.

Photograph: David M Benett/Dave Benett/Getty Images for Eco-Age



The environmental writer and expert Lucy Siegle said: “Circularity is an exciting opportunity, where it is genuine – but it has been hijacked.” Consumers were being misled, she added. “There is this idea that plastic is infinitely recyclable, and that’s just not the case.”

Alberto Candiani, the owner of Candiani Denim, a small Milan-based brand that produces the world’s first biodegradable jeans, believes that while the catwalk fashion for upcycling may not be an effective sustainability model at lower price points, high fashion has an important leadership role to play in pioneering better fabric production.

Approximately 65% of clothes on sale today are made from polyester, the base material of which is either gas or oil. Candiani has created a biodegradable plant-based denim, which is compostable “and even beneficial for the soil – fertiliser for cotton”.

Candiani believes that the fashion industry should capitalise upon high-spending fashion consumers’ interest in sustainability to fund research into future regenerative fabrics. The premium American denim brand Frame, which has boutiques in Chelsea, London, as well as New York, LA and Aspen, has partnered with Candiani on a new upmarket range of sustainable jeans.

Text 2

https://www.theguardian.com/lifeandstyle/2021/oct/08/can-i-recycle-a-pizza-box-we-ask-the-expert

Conversations with experts Recycling

Interview

Can I recycle a pizza box? We ask the expert

Coco Khan

Recycling specialist Adam Herriott on what happens when household waste goes in the wrong bin – and what to do with compostable coffee-cup lids



@cocobyname

Fri 8 Oct 2021 15.00 BST Illustration: Timo Kuilder/The Guardian

Of all the memories I have of the pandemic last year, the image of bins sticks in my mind. Black bins piled high, green recycling bins stuffed with packaging from online deliveries and takeaways. Occasionally, I'd see a pizza box resting on top, as if whoever had left it was unsure where it could or should fit in. According to research, the amount of waste produced by each household in Britain rose by a fifth last year. But are we dealing with it in the right way? And where should that pizza box go?

I spoke to Adam Herriott, resource management specialist at Waste and Resources Action Programme (Wrap), a charity that focuses on recycling and the circular economy.

Putting the wrong thing in the wrong bin is known as 'recycling contamination'. Is it a problem?

It's a big issue, because it only takes one person on your road to put rubbish in their recycling bin for the whole truckload to be rejected. Before I worked at Wrap, I was a recycling manager at a place where materials are separated, and our rejection rate was about 9% of vehicle loads.

That's high. What sort of stuff were people putting in their bins?

All sorts. Firearms. Animals.

I did not expect this conversation to take such a turn.
Mostly, it's the stuff that should go in the regular bin. It's important people don't "wish-cycle" – where they are not sure but put it in anyway.

I've also heard it called 'aspirational recycling', which makes it sound weirdly glamorous.
It happens all the time. People need to check with their council or use Recycle Now's guide. Commingled bins used to be the thing, but segregated bins assure quality. If the paper and cardboard in your bin is kept clean and dry, it can easily be recycled, so it's valuable.

Where does a pizza box fit? It's not exactly clean.
It's fine to be recycled as long as there's no cheese stuck on the box, in which case, rip that bit off. It's what we call "3D waste" – food and other solids – that's the problem. And give containers a rinse. Wash and squash.

It's probably not great that takeaway places switched to cardboard as part of the war on plastic if it ends up too soggy to be recycled.
We would never say one material is better than another. We just ask people and businesses to look at the bigger picture. Take compostable coffee-cup lids: if you don't have a food waste bin or a home composting system, it will end up in the regular bin. Or sometimes people think it's plastic. If compostables get in with the plastics, it can cause big problems.

This all sounds a bit high stakes. I thought this conversation would help my anxiety dreams.
One wrong thing in the recycling can be handled – it's just when there's too much of it. For example, people put nappies in because they're papery, even though they're full of …

3D waste.
Right. It can get everywhere in the back of a vehicle.

How did the pandemic change our recycling habits?
Everyone's bins looked different. Mine was full of glass, until I switched to boxed wine. We're waiting on the official data but, anecdotally, it sounds as if we recycled more, yes. But food on pizza boxes wasn't a problem. I'd never waste good pizza.

Text 3

https://birmingham.greenparty.org.uk/2021/07/05/how-can-we-really-be-a-clean-and-green-city/

HOW CAN WE REALLY BE A CLEAN AND GREEN CITY?

Posted on 5th July 2021 (6th July 2021) by brumguvnor

Birmingham City Council should feel ashamed of its record on recycling and waste management. The local authority lies third from bottom of the recycling league table compiled by the Department for Environment, Food & Rural Affairs (DEFRA), with a pitiful 23.6% of waste recycled last year.

To become a truly clean and green city, as Birmingham City Council's marketing material proclaims, we need a radical overhaul of the way waste is managed in the city. Almost no progress has been made in the last decade. Birmingham recycled 24% of waste in 2014, so the rate has actually dropped since then!

The first measure that needs to be taken is to abandon incineration. The Tyseley Incinerator is swallowing up over two thirds of all the waste in Birmingham and is the biggest single contributor to CO2 emissions in the city. Until we close this dirty, outdated burner down we will never reach the goal of 70% of waste being recycled, or get the city's CO2 emissions down to net zero.

All of the top performing local authorities in the country do well because of their food waste and green waste collections. Birmingham City Council, on the other hand, has tried to focus its efforts on encouraging behaviour change, in the hope that people will waste less food. However, it is obvious that this approach is not working. In 2015, it was reported that at least 41% of the contents of Birmingham residents' general waste is food waste.

Bristol is the best performing of England's large cities, but even they found that food waste still made up nearly 25% of their general waste. They launched a campaign to deal with this which worked so well that there was a 10% drop in the volume of general waste collected and a 16% increase in the amount of food waste being collected separately. This food waste goes into an anaerobic digester, which means more clean energy being produced as well as lower overall CO2 emissions.

Birmingham City Council urgently needs to invest in setting up similar systems to Bristol instead of continuing with incineration. A network of anaerobic digesters* and a pyrolysis plant* would ensure far better outcomes for the city. Such transformational measures must be taken as soon as possible, so that Birmingham becomes a leader on the journey towards zero waste.

What do we propose?

- Adopt a circular economy waste policy – we should be promoting community sharing, reuse and recycling across the city.
- Bring in community engagement and information campaigns to explain the aims of a new waste strategy and motivate people to recycle more. If people understand which items they can separate for recycling, what happens to their waste and why it is important they are much more likely to do it.
- Introduce weekly food waste collections as a matter of priority, rather than the waiting for the government to force the council to take action.
- Invest in anaerobic digestion, in-vessel composting* and pyrolysis plants.
- Look for ways to increase the range of items that can be collected for recycling from people's homes.
- Currently the council pays very high 'gate fees' for all the waste burnt in the incinerator. If we stop burning waste this money could be reallocated to pay for new, improved doorstep collection systems.

* An anaerobic digester is an industrial system that supports a natural process to treat waste, produce biogas that can be used to power electricity generators, provide heat and produce soil improving material. It is similar to composting, in that microorganisms break down organic matter, but without oxygen.

* Pyrolysis is an industrial system that can process biomass, municipal solid waste, waste plastic, waste rubber (tire), industrial waste, agricultural waste, and other organic solid waste. This waste can be converted into fuel and chemical products in a closed environment without oxygen, so that they are easy to store and transport. This means that there are very low carbon emissions involved.

* With In-Vessel Composting (IVC) garden and food waste are collected and composted together in one container. This would also enable the council to bring in free garden waste collections (for which there is currently a fee) which would increase the overall popularity of the scheme.

Posted in Birmingham City Council, Recycling, waste

‹ Action on air pollution in Birmingham is long overdue

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